



Team behind 100+ tape-outs

than an Applied Sciences course.”

Even though Chitra had already paid fees for the latter, being a volleyball player, she grabbed the opportunity thrown at her and went on to apply for the engineering course. But soon enough, another choice lay in front of her. “I got a seat in civil engineering. That was the last thing I wanted to do!”

Fascinated by the Sony record player and Walkman, young Chitra’s eyes used to twinkle at the sight of the shiny screens in electronics product showrooms. “I did not necessarily want to open up those products, but I was always attracted to them. So, I decided, I want to do electronics engineering.” Once she had made up her mind, nothing could stand in her way. As luck would have it, one of her friends wanted to take up civil engineering in the same college. The two exchanged seats, paving the way for Chitra’s chariot into the chip industry.

Chronicles of the cycle

Engineering for a middle-class day scholar from a humble background in 1980 was no mean feat. Every morning, the neighbourhood in

South Coimbatore’s Saibaba Colony saw a young girl dressed in a long cotton skirt, ferociously pedalling her way on an ancient, modified men’s bicycle, the front bar chopped off to revamp it into a ladies’ bicycle. Behind her, in the carrier seat, sat a younger demure girl, holding on tightly to a huge container. The rider dropped off her sister at the bus stop and then cycled to her grandmother’s house, filled up the water container and cycled back home, without spilling a single drop.

“After dropping my sister and

delivering water for Amma at home, I picked up my bag and cycled back to my college, which was another three-and-a-half kilometres away. My friend Sivakami, another day scholar, sat behind me reading out lecture notes,” recalls Chitra. Sivakami is now a retired General Manager in the telecom circle.

What about the lampooning and the ridicule that college students engaged in? “Who had time to dwell on that! While the hostellers bunked classes

and went for movies, being a day scholar, I had to rush to my classes and occupy the first bench to take down all the notes and be the first one in the library to get my hand on the books. I could not afford to be late anywhere,” she quips.

Nerdy Chitra knew that being late to the library meant someone else would get the required books before her. These seeds of punctuality started sprouting, later aiding her in rolling out silicon tape-outs on schedule with successful first-time working silicon.



Best Design Team award-winners for Open-Silicon

Learning Kannada

As a part of the first four-year batch of engineers, Chitra completed her graduation in 1984, but the joy of a white-collar job in DRDO or Bharat Electronics did not materialise for her. Chitra and her batch-mates graduated along with their seniors, further delaying the placements. Recognising her responsibilities towards her family and a younger sister, who was studying medicine, Chitra knew she had to have a job, the day she graduated. Taking up the role